

Philosophy as a Way of Life: Narayana Guru

Philosophy can be practised in different ways. In ancient Western traditions and some Indian schools of thought, philosophy was not just a subject to study but a *way of life*. A philosopher was expected to live according to the principles of philosophy. This helped people think differently and transform their lives. Academic philosophy and philosophy as a way of life do not contradict each other. One focuses on abstract ideas, while the other applies those ideas in daily life.

Narayana Guru was a philosopher who transformed the social and cultural life of Kerala during the early period of modernity. He wrote both prose and poetry and was fluent in Sanskrit, Malayalam, and Tamil. His originality as a philosopher can be understood through his unique approach.

1. Poetising Instead of Philosophising

Narayana Guru used the word “arivu” (knowledge) in his writings, but his approach was not based on rational arguments or academic philosophy. Instead, he expressed his ideas through ‘poetry’. He was not interested in proving the ideas of any one philosophical school such as ‘Advaita’, or “Buddhism”. For him, these were not fixed philosophical truths but “poetic truths”. Although he first wrote in prose, he later turned to writing poetry. This change was important because poetry became his way of thinking and expressing ideas. His poems should not be understood as arguments supporting any single philosophical theory. Instead, they combine ideas from different Indian traditions in a creative and original way.

Narayana Guru treated poetry like an “*experimental laboratory*”, where he freely mixed insights from many traditions without strictly following any one school of thought. Therefore, he is remembered as a philosopher not only because of the books he wrote but also because he lived according to his philosophy. His philosophy was reflected in his way of life and his deep commitment to truth, equality, and social transformation.

Narayana Guru did not simply follow social, cultural, or religious traditions. Instead, he lived according to his own philosophical principles. His way of life transformed the social, cultural, and religious life of Kerala. Because of this, he is often regarded as the **founder of Kerala modernity**. His philosophy cannot be explained by any single school of thought such as Advaita, Saivism, or Buddhism. He was creative in both his ideas and actions. For Guru, thinking itself was an act of creation. His body, life, actions, and words were all

expressions of his philosophy. His ways of living, acting, and knowing were closely connected.

Narayana Guru believed that knowledge (arivu) was only the starting point, not the final goal. He was more interested in living according to knowledge than merely collecting it. His life showed great honesty, commitment, and unity between thought and action.

2. Translation Instead of Interpretation

Narayana Guru did not try to explain or defend any metaphysical theory. Instead, he wanted to **translate philosophical and poetic truths into everyday life**. For him, poetry was a way of thinking and living, not just a form of literature. He believed that words should bring positive changes in people's lives. Guru wrote in many forms such as Keerthana's, prayers, hymns, and verses. These writings were not meant only to provide information. Their purpose was to inspire, transform, and shape the minds and lives of readers and listeners. Learning, according to Guru, should develop not only intelligence but also imagination, sensitivity, and willpower. One of his famous works is **“Athmopadesa Satakam (One Hundred Verses in Self-Counselling)”**. This work does not teach a particular philosophical system. Instead, it encourages people to understand themselves and apply philosophical insights in their own lives. Guru believed that true philosophy should be practised in daily life and should help people become better human beings.